effect’. This meant that Palit, the only senior officer who knew the Kameng Frontier Division first-hand, was no longer in NEFA.

THE CHANGE OF GUARD

General Thimayya retired on 7 May 1961, handing over to General Pran Thapar. Many service officers felt Thimayya should have resigned immediately after Prime Minister Nehru’s statements in Parliament in September 1959. The constant eroding of his authority by the Menon-Kaul partnership saw him hang up his boots ‘a sad and disillusioned man; his advice regarding China ignored and the Army in the same state of unreadiness for its ordained tasks’. On one of his last visits to some of the formations, he is reported to have said: ‘I hope that I am not leaving you as cannon-fodder for the Chinese. God bless you all.’

With Thimayya went Thorat, the Eastern Army Commander. Despite being on the wrong side of the Nehru-Menon clique, many officers still expected Thorat to make the cut on the basis of sheer merit. With the departure of the two most respected officers in the Indian Army, a mass clearing of the stables was undertaken. Lieutenant General Bijji Kaul had already been officiating as the CGS for the past few months. Bogey Sen moved to Lucknow to take over command from Thorat, while Lieutenant General Daulet Singh was chosen to replace Pran Thapar as the Western Army Commander. In Army HQ, almost all key appointments—including the Director, Military Operations and Director, Military Intelligence—were to be staffed by officers who were handpicked by Kaul himself.

With the exit of Thimayya and Thorat, Lieutenant General S. D. Verma, GOC of XV Corps that was looking after Kashmir and Ladakh, also put in his papers. Krishna Menon and Kaul, not just content to see these officers go home on retirement, continued to further discredit other officers who were considered to be Thimayya loyalists. Just before Thimayya’s formal retirement, the Menon-Kaul duo even went so far as to institute an enquiry on the charge of treason against the outgoing army chief on frivolous grounds. The charge of ‘treason’ instituted against Thimayya was symptomatic of the times. The highly respected Verma, who had been expected to take over Western Command, eventually left India to seek refuge in London in order to get away from the vindictiveness of the powers that be. Another officer caught in the crossfire of vendetta was Major